level of bombing was insufficient. “People were thrilled to feel this sense of togetherness, this feeling of ‘us against them.’ There’s a good sense of nationalism, the likes of which this country has not seen in decades,” said Dr Tamar Hermann, the chief pollster at IDI.

The organizers of the first rally tried again on 26 July, this time in Rabin Square, named after the prime minister who was slain there in 1995. The plaza, which sits below City Hall, is a focal point for Israeli civil society: it was the site of Peace Now’s massive protest against the Lebanon war in 1982, and a popular location for election rallies.

Hours before the rally was meant to begin, though, the police canceled the permit, arguing that the threat of rocket attacks made such a large gathering unsafe. It was due to coincide with the end of a brief “humanitarian ceasefire”. The permit was only reinstated an hour before the rally, too late for buses to bring in demonstrators from outside Tel Aviv. Just 5,000 people turned up. They spelled out the words “forgive us” in Hebrew using 1,043 candles—the number of Israelis and Palestinians who had been killed up to that point. A lawmaker from Hadash, the Communist party, gave a speech, as did Israeli and Palestinian members of Combatants for Peace, an organization that brings together former soldiers and militants. But there were no representatives of the larger political parties, nor leaders of activist groups like Peace Now. “We feel very isolated, it’s true,” one protester said at the Tel Aviv rally. “Nobody to the right of Zehava Gal-On [a prominent member of Meretz] has spoken out against the situation.”

“It’s still not the mainstream Israeli peace movement that was protesting,” Hagit Ofran, the director of the settlement project at Peace Now, told me after the rally. “It’s very hard to call for stopping the war when the emotions are so strong, when the feelings are that Hamas is not willing to stop either.”

Officers had learned their lessons from the previous protest, and spent much of the evening trying to separate the crowd from a smaller group of pro-war demonstrators. They dispersed the rally at 10 pm, again citing the threat of rockets. As the anti-war protesters trickled away, they were chased down and attacked by their nationalist counterparts, beaten with metal rods and doused with pepper spray. This time at least eight people were hospitalized.

There were a few more scattered protests in the weeks to come, but nothing that attracted a sizable crowd, owing to a combination of fatigue